

Parades, Flags, Carnivals, and Riots: Public Space, Contestation, and Transformation in Northern Ireland

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This paper explores one of the defining aspects of politics and identity in Northern Ireland: the control and utilization of public space, particularly urban public space. Ethnopolitical conflict consistently reveals itself through contestation over public space. The role of ritual events is important in the development of political identity and group cohesion. The symbolic landscape will be constructed through displays of identity by dominant groups and their ability to control that landscape by inhibiting displays by other groups. This will reveal itself through frequent contests over rituals and symbols. This paper looks at the role of ritual events in civic spaces in Belfast but particularly asks what role they might play in conflict transformation. The 1998 agreement offered political structures that provided for shared power after 30 years of violent conflict. At the same time, there was an increase in contestation over public space as political groups within the previously marginalized Catholic community demanded recognition within the public sphere and a rebalancing of the public space through changes to the previously dominant Protestant and Unionist expression of identity. The paper concludes by suggesting that in “shared space” a new civic identity that spans the political and ethnic divisions has started to develop in Belfast and that this might evolve despite an increased residential division throughout the urban area.

Keywords: public space, conflict transformation, ritual, Northern Ireland

On December 3, 2012, after a vote in the Belfast City Council, the Union flag, which had flown every day of the year over City Hall, was taken down. In a city that was formerly a bastion of power for the political parties representing the British Unionist identity of Protestants in Northern Ireland, a coalition of Irish Republican and Nationalist councilors along with

those from the cross-community Alliance Party changed the policy so that the flag would only fly on designated days over the most prominent public building in Northern Ireland. The immediate response saw 2,000 demonstrators protest outside City Hall, and in the weeks that followed, main roads in the city were blocked as a series of protests took place every Saturday, resulting in clashes with police and sporadic violence erupting at interfaces between Catholic and Protestant residential areas.

Two years later, a few hundred protestors gather outside of City Hall every Saturday to protest the decision, making claims that their Britishness is under threat. The events have become just another in an annual cycle of contestation over public space through parades, commemoration, and the flying of flags that seem to encapsulate the ethnopolitical divisions in Northern Ireland. In December 2014, U.S. diplomat Richard Haass, at the behest of the power-sharing government in Northern Ireland, published the result of months of talks between political parties trying to come up with new ways of managing parades, flags, and dealing

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with the legacy of 30 years of violence. He achieved no agreement.

Since Northern Ireland came into existence in 1921, the use of public space has had a particular role in defining ethnic identities. Orange parades dominated the civic space while symbols and rituals of Irish nationalism were restricted to very specific areas through the use of policing and emergency legislation. At the same time, urban and rural residential areas were frequently defined as “Protestant”, therefore Unionist and “Catholic” and therefore Irish Nationalist. The everyday definition of space was often underwritten by rioting that was frequently sparked by the range of commemorations and displays of symbols at particular times of the year. When the hegemony of unionism in public space was sufficiently threatened by the civil rights movement from 1967 onward, public order began to break down completely and paramilitary groups, the Irish Republican Army (IRA) and the loyalist Ulster Volunteer Force (UVF), competed with the forces of the state over the legitimate use of violence, creating “No Go” areas under their control, rather than that of the police. In turn, city and town centers became zones of security. Economic and civic life was hampered as urban space was designed to resist the car bomb. Protestant and Catholic working-class populations increasingly lived in separate places divided by high interface walls. More than 3,500 people died between 1969 and 1998.

When in the 1990s a peace process developed and politics began to become more prominent than violence as a strategy for paramilitary groups, the civic sphere became a site for political contest. Previously hegemonic “traditional” Orange parades were opposed in several places whereas Irish Republicans demanded, and got, the right to hold their demonstrations in the center of Belfast. Government policy became one of shared space, and new attempts were made to manage how public spaces were managed.

Northern Ireland provides a very clear example of the relationship between conflict and public space and the defining of that space as “territory.” As violence increased in 1969, it was clear that previously more latent physical and social boundaries that had been in existence became more pertinent and, literally, as well as sociologically, more heavily policed. In terms

of architecture, the very physical manifestation of this was the building of walls separating groups of people that define themselves as Irish Nationalist and Catholic or British, Unionist and Protestant. These semipermanent constructions leave a sustained legacy that even within a peace process, and the measurably reduced levels of violence since 1998, is difficult to remove. In addition, the evidence that residential segregation remains high gives the impression that the peace process created little change in fundamental social relationships. This is further evidenced by the ongoing annual cycle of disputes over the rights of parades organized by the Protestant Orange Order, and other Unionist organizations, to march through areas seen territorially as Catholic and Nationalist. These require an increasingly complex legal and instructional architecture to manage and each year result in rioting that makes international news. This affects what has usefully been termed the *symbolic landscape* (Ross, 2009).

In contrast to all of the examples of contestation, I suggest, albeit tentatively, that there is evidence from Northern Ireland that a conflict transformation process is revealing itself through changes in the use of public space. This has largely taken place in what might be termed the *civic space*, and it is most obvious in the larger urban areas of Belfast and Derry/Londonderry. It is revealed through some significant legal and policy changes; through the development of a range of rituals, festivals, and events with significant participation; and through the development of identities that potentially cut across the ethnopolitical divide of Catholic/Nationalist and Protestant/Unionist. In making this argument, I am not suggesting that we have seen a definitive change in the sociopolitical relationships in Northern Ireland; rather, I am highlighting that there is some evidence of change, and perhaps more particularly, that in conflict transformation processes, the role played by rituals in identity formation is important and needs to be addressed. In particular, that the management of public space and the events that take place in them needs to be considered along with the building of new political and legal structures that are the common ground for peace processes. Given that rituals play an important role in sociality and identity, they are logically capable of playing a role in

peace building just as they can be central to the organization of conflicting identities.

Understanding the contestation of public spaces demands a comprehension of the relationship of human beings, and particularly senses of group identity, in relation to the places that they live in and use. It demands an understanding of the way those group identities are experienced and utilized through expressions in the public space, the focus of which in this paper is ritual. Furthermore, it demands an understanding of how power is enacted through those public spaces.

Identity, Ritual, and Social Change

The relationship between ritual, symbols, and identity is central to modern politics. All groups and organizations use forms of ritual and symbolic representation (branding) to invest a sense of belonging into their members (Kertzer, 1988, p. 16). This is understood by those with power who will attempt to utilize rituals and the language of symbols to enhance their power, and it is also understood by the relatively powerless that can use ritual as expression of group cohesion to influence those with power. The creation of social cohesion is a theme that runs through the social sciences from the social identity theories of Tajfel (1981) right through Durkheimian sociology and anthropology. Although the processes by which ritual create a senses of cohesion are less well understood and open to academic debate, the ever-present nature of rituals in social and political processes leaves little doubt of its importance.

Consequently, the role played by rituals at points of social conflict has long been of interest (Gluckman, 1963, 1970). Taking a minimal definition, as Jenkins puts it, identification is “the ways in which individuals and collectives are distinguished in their social relations with other individuals and collectives” (Jenkins, 2004, p. 5). Given that the identities that arise from this, similar to the social relationships they are constructed from, are not fixed, then the role of ritual in the construction of identity, particularly in periods of social change, becomes very interesting. Ross (2009, pp. 12–17) describes them as psychocultural dramas, drawing on Victor Turners’ (1974) idea of a social drama, when looking at divided societies, to emphasize the deeply rooted psychological dynamics of

conflict that arise over competing identities (Ross, 2009, p. 12). However, Ross also argues that within contested cultural spaces there are opportunities for constructive conflict management (Ross, 2009, p. 18). By the same logic that suggests that rituals provide social cohesion for competing identity groups, ritual can also provide a broad cohesion either through alternative narratives being dramatically played out or perhaps through a sense of citizenship that arises through participation in rituals. Thus, to take an example that will be examined in this paper, how might Catholic Nationalists experience a sense in citizenship in Northern Ireland if they participate in St. Patrick’s Day events at the heart of the city, compared with the period up until the early 1990s when no expressions of Irish nationalism were allowed into the city?

Conflict and the Symbolic Landscape in Belfast

This paper takes a broadly ethnographic approach to these issues. Drawing upon anthropology, it examines some of the changes that have taken place in Belfast since the 1960s. In doing so, I provide some evidence of change since the 1960s that suggests greater sharing of the public spaces in the center of the city. This at least allows us to posit a hypothesis that there is some causal relationship between participation in diverse ritual events in the city and a more sustainable peace process. Of course, causation may flow in several directions, but I contend that the importance of providing a vibrant shared public sphere in the development of a peace process in a divided society is clear.

The importance of the city of Belfast in exploring the nature of conflict in Northern Ireland was underlined by the urban spatial turn in anthropological research in the region in the 1980s (Aretxaga, 1997; Bryan, 2000; Buckley & Kenny, 1995; Curtin, Donnan, & Wilson, 1993; Feldman, 1991; Jarman, 1997; Buckley, 1998; O’Reilly, 1999; Santino, 2001; Sluka, 1989). The work of anthropologists, more theoretically diverse than the earlier rural-based ethnographies, contributed to a substantial research agenda looking at territory and public space drawing on a range of disciplines, particularly geography and urban planning (see, e.g., Boal, 1995; Boal & Murray, 1977; Bollens, 1999; Gaffikin & Morrissey, 2011; Murtagh,

2002; Neill, 2004; Shirlow, 2000; Shirlow & Murtagh, 2006). What makes this theme particularly pertinent is that over the same period of time as Northern Ireland moved from low-level war to an uneasy peace, the management of public space was a major concern for the agencies of the state. Between 1998 and 2008 there were 5 pieces of legislation relating directly to the management of demonstrations and parades and at least 13 reviews, policy reports, protocols, and guidelines relating to public space covering the same period. This just pertains to issues over parades, demonstrations, and the display of symbols, and it looks at major government initiatives. It does not include the huge amount of policy work done within local councils across the region within the community relations agenda. Just as areas of Belfast and other urban parts of Northern Ireland developed “interfaces” separating Protestant and Catholic residential areas, so too a central aspect of policy after the 1998 Multi-party Agreement was the development of a *Shared Future* policy, in which shared space was developed (Komarova, 2008; Office of the First and Deputy First Minister, 2005).

Much of the research exploring public space in Belfast has concentrated on residential areas and has revealed increased division and a growing number of interface areas since the signing of the agreement in 1998 (Shirlow & Murtagh, 2006). However, examining some of the public events that have taken place around the center of Belfast since the 1960s, it becomes clear that not only are the events indicative of broader political changes, but perhaps more interestingly they are also precursors or even drivers of political change. As such, by looking at practical examples of how public space in Belfast city center is used, we have the opportunity of developing a more sophisticated analysis of different types of shared space.

Hegemonic control of civic space in Belfast by the politics of unionism developed in the second half of the 19th century and was reinforced when Belfast became the capital of Northern Ireland in 1921. Orange parades dominated the civic sphere (Bryan, 2000). Although public authorities never funded the parades as such, they received massive support through policing and other resources, and the parades were occasions at which Unionist politicians defined the nature of the civic. The political

strength of the parades derived from a broad cross-class appeal within the Unionist political identity. However, as a civic event they were problematic as their plebeian nature, with particularly high levels of drinking and sectarianism, broke some of the rules of the civic, legally and normatively defined. In other words, some of the behavior of participants did not meet the standards desired in ‘respectable society’.

After 1921, the existence of the Irish Free State offered an apparent external threat to Northern Ireland, at least from the perspective of most Unionists and the Catholic population providing the internal threat around which the discourses of Britishness were built. Irish nationalism had shifted from the constitutional political formations of the Irish National Party to the Irish republicanism of Sinn Féin and an annual commemorative cycle that now incorporated the 1916 Easter Rising in Dublin. Legislation, in the form of the Civil Authorities (Special Powers) Act of 1922, was hastily introduced by the new Unionist regime in Northern Ireland giving significant powers to the predominantly Protestant Royal Ulster Constabulary (RUC) to control public order. Consequently, demonstrations of an overtly Irish republican nature never appeared in the center of Belfast and civic space took on a broadly Unionist and British identity (Bryan & Jarman, 1998). Postwar legislation to control public space in Northern Ireland was reinforced with the Public Order Act (NI) of 1951 and the Flags and Emblems (Display) Act of 1954. This said, examples of political protests in Belfast in the early 1960s reveal a relatively vibrant political space (Nagle, 2008a, 2008b, 2009).

Orange parades in Belfast, by far the largest public events in the city, reflected political unionism in general and often boasted senior Unionist government ministers in their ranks. However, the civic life of the city has been reflected in other events such as the Lord Mayors’ Show, organized by the Junior Chamber of Commerce. In the 1960s, the Lord Mayors’ Show contained approximately 100 floats representing a broad spectrum of civic life including charities, major local companies, and various representations of the military. The event reflected the nature of civic space at the time, espousing Unionist values, and it appeared to be relatively uncontested. However, by the 1970s and 1980s, the high point of the violent conflict,

conditions were very different. The city center had seen bombs planted by the IRA and UVF and security measures developed from the early 1970s onward, including the use of the British Army as a policing institution. The economic effect on the city was obvious, let alone the image Belfast promoted throughout the world. The Lord Mayors' Show went into decline. By 1980, the President of the Chamber of Commerce was appealing for the big employers, who had not recently taken part in the Lord Mayors' Show, to return ("Extra Cash Needed to Get," *Irish News*, 1980). By 1994, the Lord Mayors' Show in Belfast had only 40 floats with all of the significant sponsorship having left the event ("Smiles for the Big Parades," *News Letter*, 1994).

In 1993, Republicans were allowed to hold a protest in the city for the first time. Intriguingly, in 1995, an Irish Republican prisoners support group *Saoirse* complained that they were not allowed to participate in the show (Doran, *Irish News*, 1995). This is significant as an attempt by Irish Republicanism to be represented in the civic center of the city. Thus, an early challenge to the Lord Mayors' Show, an event of such previous Unionist civic pride, is particularly interesting and clearly reflected the changing political environment. Sinn Féin had significant representation in the city council and was increasingly trying to play its part in civic life. In 1998, the Lord Mayors' Parade, led for the first time by an Irish Nationalist mayor, was described as a "carnival" with Chinese dragons and a float from London's Notting Hill Carnival. What seems to be taking place was a new negotiated identity for the event. Thus, by 2008, the Lord Mayors' Carnival was made up of community groups and performers from various ethnic backgrounds. The Lord Mayors' Show, now an attempt to represent multiculturalism, looked very different from those of 40 years earlier.

By way of comparison, on March, 17, 2006, a St. Patrick's Day carnival was organized through the center of the city. The main part of the parade also took the form of a multiethnic carnival with images of St. Patrick being provided by several of the community groups involved. Children were handed multicolored shamrocks by council workers, the green shamrock being viewed as apparently unacceptable to some Unionist councilors. Under the coun-

cil's guidelines for events, no political flags (which in theory includes the Union "Jack" flag and Tricolour) were to be carried in the carnival parade or at the staged event. Although a few Tricolours were carried in the parade by people walking along with the parade, and there were some being carried by spectators, only approximately 100 were waved by the 4,000 spectators at the staged event. So how did Belfast City Council come to be organizing a St. Patrick's Day carnival parade as part of its calendar of civic events?

In March 1998, the first St. Patrick's Day event took place in the city center. Organizers came from the West Belfast Festival, which itself was born out of the internment commemorations in the west of the city but had developed with some public funding. The nature of these early St. Patrick's Day parades in Belfast, which included a range of Nationalist and Republican symbols and the Republican prisoner support groups that had attempted to enter the Lord Mayors' Show in 1995, was widely viewed as political. The event was very clearly Irish Republicanism entering the civic sphere in its broadest sense, recognition, at least, that the Tricolour could be waved in the center of Belfast. In this sense, it was an expression of the Sinn Féin demand for *parity of esteem*, suggesting, not unreasonably, that they should get the use of public space in the way that Unionists have long got to use it.

What is interesting is that at the same time that this took place, a debate started as to what role the council should play in funding the event. The debate was made more interesting because St. Patrick, as an Irish saint that allegedly brought Christianity to Ireland, had long been recognized and celebrated by Protestants in Ireland as well as Catholics (Cronin & Adair, 2002). As such, those in the council wishing to develop the community relations agenda could see utility in using the St. Patrick's Day events for developing "good relations" (Institute of Irish Studies, 2006, pp. 21–31).

These two examples of events in the central spaces of Belfast—the Lord Mayors' Show pre-existing and St. Patrick's Day new—show ethnographic evidence of attempting to reflect a broader, more inclusive identity. St. Patrick's Day becomes recognized by the Belfast City Council on its calendar of civic events. In addition, events reflecting the politics of Irish Re-

publicanism also took place in the city center. Both in terms of events funded and encouraged by the civic authorities and simply at the level of freedom of assembly, we can identify a clear change in the use of the public space. Other events are further evidence of this shift. The Gay Pride Parade in Belfast has grown significantly since 2000, and in terms of the parade it is now bigger than St. Patrick's Day and the Lord Mayors' Show. There remains a core of religious protestors contesting the event, but they are marginalized in terms of numbers and the way the event is supported in the mainstream media. Pride is part of civic life in Belfast. In addition, the Belfast City Council has sought to attract high-profile international events such as the MTV awards in 2011 and the Giro D'Italia cycle race in 2014. Perhaps more significantly in terms of political identity, in 2000 the World Irish Dance Championships were held at Belfast's Waterfront Hall with surrounding public spaces being decorated with images of Irish dancers. Put simply, the space around City Hall in Belfast, formerly dominated by British unionism, now exhibited a more multicultural and diverse identity including prominent symbols of Irishness. Even the Twelfth of July Orange Parades tried to create a new image by branding the day as Orangefest utilizing some public funding.

All of this is not conclusive evidence of a fundamental change in the polarized political identities exhibited in Northern Ireland. To repeat, evidence suggests that residential segregation became greater after the 1998 agreement. In addition, voting at local and national elections has resolutely maintained the position of the ethnically based Nationalist and Unionist political parties. Furthermore, there are annual disputes over Orange parades taking routes through or near Catholic residential areas sometimes leading to serious rioting. There is a lot of evidence to suggest society in Northern Ireland is as divided as it has been since the 1960s. However, if we are to take seriously the idea that rituals matter, then we have to look at the alternative narratives appearing in the public, civic spaces of the city. If we note a significant increase in the organization of events with popular participation that either involve Catholics and Protestants or project alternative identities, and if we also note that, unlike in the 1960s, representations of Catholic, Irish Nationalist,

and Republican identities are given access to those civic spaces, albeit on different days to those of the Orange Order, then there appears to be a process taking place that might approximate a greater sharing of space. Without judging why it has happened, or what effect it has had, it is reasonable to say that, in terms of the civic public spaces, in the center of Belfast things have changed.

What might drive this change? The first thing to note is the legal changes that were introduced as a direct result of the 1998 agreement. The Northern Ireland Act of 1998 imposed upon public authorities a legal duty to promote equality and the desirability of promoting good relations (Section 75). This imposes statutory duties upon public authorities, including, obviously, local councils.

Section 75.

(1) A public authority shall in carrying out its functions relating to Northern Ireland have due regard to the need to promote equality of opportunity –

- a) between persons of different religious belief, political opinion, racial group, age, material status or sexual orientation;
- b) between men and women generally;
- c) between persons with a disability and persons without; and
- d) between persons with dependents and persons without.

(2) Without prejudice to its obligations under subsection (1), a public authority shall in carrying out its functions relating to Northern Ireland have regard to the desirability of promoting good relations between persons of different religious belief, political opinion or racial groups.

The implications of this legislation took time to feed through, but councils had to be cognizant of the practice of organizing events and providing public funding. When organizing events Belfast City Council attempts to comply with policies that create a shared space. So, for example, as with all events, at the major Giro d'Italia Opening on 8 May, 2014 conditions included 'Flags, emblems or other paraphernalia of a political, sectarian, racist or partisan nature will not be permitted on site.'

These policies form part of a broader government policy to create shared space. This was most clearly articulated in 2005 in the *A Shared Future* (2005) policy produced by the Office of

the First Minister and Deputy First Minister (OFMDFM) under direct rule. The overall aim of the *Shared Future* policy is

... to establish, over time, a shared society defined by a culture of tolerance: a normal, civic society, in which all individuals are considered as equals, where differences are resolved through dialogue in the public sphere, and where all individuals are treated impartially. A society where there is equity, respect for diversity and recognition of our interdependence (Office of the First Minister and Deputy First Minister, 2005; 1.2.1).

In 2004 Belfast City Council published a good relations strategy that, among other aims, looked to celebrate diversity (Belfast City Council, 2004). The evolution of policy and practice over the following 10 years from 2004 has been significant. The Council has an Equality Scheme (2001, revised in 2012), a Good Relations Strategy (2004), and a Peace and Reconciliation Action Plan (2011).

It was not only the legislative and policy environment that changed but also the political balance of power. In the 1990s Sinn Féin, the political party derived from the Provisional IRA, became the largest political party in the Belfast City Council. This gave them access to important committees, and by 2014 four Sinn Féin councilors had taken the role as mayor of Belfast. No one party had a majority in City Hall, and the Alliance party held the balance of power. They have been very supportive of policies around *A Shared Future* policy and, as discussed at the start of this paper, in December 2012 they voted with Nationalist councilors to reduce the number of days the Union flag was flown above City Hall.

Power in Belfast had changed. The symbolic landscape in the city had changed. Returning to one of our examples, this had a direct influence on the organizing of St. Patrick's Day. In 2005, after recommendations from the council's Good Relations Panel, the council agreed that it should take the lead in organizing an "inclusive" outdoor event for the following year's St. Patrick's Day. With the council running the event, attempts to reduce the number of Tricolours, replacing them with multicolored shamrocks, took a high profile. Whereas in 2006 stewards working for the council were apprehensive at asking people to put Tricolours away, at the 2008 event they were much more confident, and when spectators were asked to "please

put the flag away because this is a cross-community event," a surprisingly large number of people accepted the request. Surveys that were conducted by the Institute of Irish Studies in 2006 and 2007 suggest that more Protestants were attending the event—12% in 2006 moving to 17.6% in 2007 (Institute of Irish Studies, 2006). As such, there is some evidence that the St. Patrick's Day event is being attended by Protestants as well as Catholics and that those participating recognize the importance of making it a shared event.

Conclusion

This paper has been premised on the idea that that public spaces play an important role in the manifestation of conflict and therefore, logically, play an important role in the transformation of conflict. A key part of the way people identify is manifest through rituals, and these rituals form part of what we might call the symbolic landscape. That symbolic landscape is often identified with contestation. However, I have argued that in a peace process, a process of conflict transformation, you would also need, and expect to see, changes in the symbolic landscape that reflect the transformation process. This might reveal itself in increased contestation as political groups that have previously worked through armed resistance now seek political recognition. However, as transformation takes place, it will also reveal itself through alternative manifestations of politics and identity that cut across ethno-political divisions. These events represent alternative forms of group cohesion.

Much of the research on Belfast has mapped increasing division and segregation in urban spaces. However, in this paper I have attempted to identify evidence that suggests that public, civic space in Belfast is being shared. By 2008 the civic space in Belfast has become quite a different place compared with the 1960s. The Irish Tricolour has entered the city, although at St. Patrick's Day in the city, to create a shared event, the carrying of the flag is now discouraged. St. Patrick's Day has become part of the broader repertoire of events taking place in public space in Belfast, but it had to conform to the contemporary definition of shared space in the city. As such, reflecting the policy of the council, to conform to the policy of sharing space, it could only work as a multiethnic carnival with few local cultural traditions in-

volved. In 2008 the event was led by an Ulster Unionist Lord Mayor of Belfast.

When we compare St. Patrick's Day to the Lord Mayors' Show, there is a strange twist. The Lord Mayors' Show has also redefined itself and taken on exactly the same form—carnival. It is ironic that a form of carnival, so often the space for resistance in other cultural contexts, has become the acceptable shared space for civic representation in contemporary Belfast. Although it could be said that carnival, as it is used in Belfast, becomes a "neutral space," the identity politics developing around it are nevertheless interesting and potentially dynamic. There is evidence that key civic events in the city have developed in a ways that mean they can be shared. In 2008, the Lord Mayors' Show, formerly a statement of Unionist pride in their industrial city, was led by a Sinn Féin mayor being transported in a rickshaw.

This paper is not intended as an argument that the divisions in Belfast are withering away. Much of the evidence points to greater division (Murtagh, 2008; Shirlow & Murtagh, 2006). Nevertheless, I do want to suggest there is potentially an alternative dynamic underway that does indicate greater shared use of certain spaces in the city. In other words, the city is potentially more divided and more shared at the same time. Speculating, we may be seeing the development of a "civic culture" or a symbolic landscape that is shared in significant respects and does offer an element of common identity to the citizens of the city. Just as rituals play a role in the maintenance of social cohesion within contesting political identity groups, and indeed contestation might increase under a transformation process, they also play a role in the development of identities that encourage reconciliation and alternative cross-cutting identities. Legislation and policy in Northern Ireland after the 1998 agreement created a structure within which events in public spaces are encouraged to reflect ideas of equality and good community relations. This paper suggests that, partly due to the changes in policies managing public space and partly due to the sharing of political power, we have indeed seen changes in the way public space, particularly around the civic spaces of City Hall, is used. The symbolic landscape in the form of a type of shared space has reflected a conflict transformation process since the agreement. The rituals on that landscape, although still reflecting ethnonationalist division, also

reflect new political circumstances and possibly a long-term change in political identities in the city.

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